Narratives of Identity, Power, and Constitutional Change in Modern Ireland: A Comprehensive Analysis

1. Introduction: The Architecture of Memory and the Politics of Future

The political landscape of the island of Ireland in the mid-2020s is defined by a complex interplay between the calcified memories of the past and the fluid, often volatile, dynamics of the present. To understand the contemporary push for Irish reunification, the electoral stagnation of Sinn Féin in the Republic, or the cultural shifts within Ulster Unionism, one must first decode the iconography that adorns the gable walls of Belfast. These murals are not merely folk art; they are open-air archives of community legitimacy, visual manifestos that claim unbroken lineages from the revolutionary period of the 1920s to the conflict of the late 20th century.

This report provides an exhaustive examination of these intersecting forces. It begins by collating and analyzing the pantheon of "radical heroes" promoted by Republican and Loyalist communities, tracing the deliberate parallels drawn between the guerillas of the War of Independence and the paramilitaries of the Troubles. It then pivots to the transformative work of Linda Ervine in East Belfast, whose "Turas" project represents a significant rupture in the traditional unionist rejection of Irish culture.

Furthermore, the report scrutinizes the financial and diplomatic engines driving the current unification debate, specifically the role of American funding bodies like Friends of Sinn Féin and the Ancient Order of Hibernians. It offers a critical post-mortem of the 2024 Irish general election, analyzing why the "inevitable" rise of Sinn Féin stalled and identifying the key policy architects within the party who operate outside the shadow of its leadership triumvirate. Finally, it situates a potential United Ireland within the broader geopolitical framework of the Commonwealth of Nations, analyzing the status of republics within that body as a potential model for accommodation.

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2. The Republican Pantheon: Iconography of Resistance in West Belfast

In the republican heartlands of West Belfast—specifically along the Falls Road, Ballymurphy, and the "International Wall" on Divis Street—history is presented not as a sequence of disjointed events, but as a singular, continuous struggle against British imperialism. The murals serve a dual purpose: to memorialize the dead and to legitimize the provisional

republican movement by anchoring it in the "unimpeachable" legacy of the 1916-1923 revolutionary period.

2.1 The Foundational Martyrs: Heroes of the 1920s

For the Republican movement, the 1920s represent the "unfinished revolution." The figures from this era selected for lionization in West Belfast murals are chosen specifically to emphasize the efficacy of physical force and the moral weight of martyrdom.

- **Dan Breen (1894–1969):** Breen is a quintessential figure in republican radical lore, celebrated for starting the War of Independence with the Soloheadbeg Ambush in 1919. In West Belfast iconography, Breen represents the "unapologetic gunman." Unlike political leaders who compromised, Breen is depicted as the archetype of the irreconcilable rebel. His memoir, *My Fight for Irish Freedom*, is a foundational text for many PIRA volunteers, and his image on murals serves to justify the guerrilla tactics used during the Troubles as being part of a noble tradition of "taking the fight to the enemy".[1]
- **Tom Barry (1897–1980):** As the commander of the West Cork Flying Column, Barry is revered for his tactical brilliance, particularly at the Kilmichael Ambush. Murals depicting Barry often focus on the discipline and effectiveness of the "Old IRA," drawing a direct visual comparison to the PIRA's "active service units" (ASUs). He is used to refute the label of "terrorist," reframing the conflict instead as a legitimate war between an occupying army and a native resistance force.[1]
- **Kevin Barry (1902–1920):** Executed at the age of 18, Kevin Barry is the primary symbol of youthful sacrifice. His inclusion in murals is almost always designed to evoke the tragedy of wasted life and to draw parallels with the young volunteers of the 1970s and 80s who died in British custody. The ballad of Kevin Barry is a staple of republican culture, and his visage on walls in Andersonstown or the Falls usually appears alongside contemporary figures to suggest that the "boy martyrs" of 1920 and 1981 are brothers in the same struggle.[3]
- **Terence MacSwiney (1879–1920):** The Lord Mayor of Cork who died after 74 days on hunger strike in Brixton Prison. MacSwiney is the intellectual and spiritual godfather of the hunger strike tactic. His central maxim—*"It is not those who can inflict the most, but those who can endure the most who will conquer"*—is inscribed on countless memorials and murals in West Belfast. He provides the theological framework for the 1981 hunger strikes, transforming the suicide of the striker into a supreme act of political defiance rather than a mortal sin or act of desperation.[1]
- **Liam Mellows (1892–1922):**
  Executed by the Free State during the Civil War, Mellows is a hero to the socialist-republican wing. He represents the danger of compromise and the betrayal by the "establishment" nationalist parties (Fine Gael/Fianna Fáil). His image warns against the internal enemy and the "counter-revolution," a theme that resonates with dissidents critical of the Good Friday Agreement.

2.2 The Modern Martyrs: Heroes of the 1970s and 1980s

The murals of the Troubles era focus heavily on the prison struggle and the "active service" of volunteers. The user specifically enquired about Frank Stagg, whose story is central to the narrative of state conflict between the Republic and the Republican movement.

- **Frank Stagg (1942–1976):** Frank Stagg's commemoration in murals is potent because it highlights the collaboration between the British and Irish governments against republicans. Stagg died on hunger strike in Wakefield Prison, England. His request to be buried with republican honors in Ballina, Co. Mayo, led to a bizarre state intervention where the Irish government hijacked his body and buried it under six feet of concrete to prevent a PIRA volley. Republicans later tunneled under the concrete to rebury him. Murals commemorating Stagg (often alongside Michael Gaughan) serve as a bitter reminder of the "criminalization" policy and the hostility of the Dublin government.[5]
- **Michael Gaughan (1949–1974):** Died in Parkhurst Prison, Isle of Wight, as a result of force-feeding during a hunger strike. Gaughan's death is depicted in murals as an example of British brutality (force-feeding) and is linked to the earlier suffering of Thomas Ashe in 1917. The repatriation of his body was a massive event in republican history, and murals capture the scale of this mourning.[6]
- **Bobby Sands (1954–1981):** Sands is the single most recognizable figure in Irish Republicanism globally. The mural on the side of the Sinn Féin office on the Falls Road (Sevastopol Street) is the "Mecca" of political tourism in Belfast. Sands represents the synthesis of the "soldier" (he was PIRA OC in the Maze) and the "statesman" (MP for Fermanagh/South Tyrone). Crucially, murals almost always depict him smiling, softening the paramilitary edge and focusing on his humanity, poetry, and ultimate sacrifice. He is the bridge between the 1920s martyrs (MacSwiney) and the modern political movement.[5]
- **Mairéad Farrell (1957–1988):** Killed by the SAS in Gibraltar, Farrell is the primary female icon of the modern conflict. Murals depict her both as a volunteer and a political thinker (she was an election candidate). She represents the feminist strand of republicanism and is visually linked to **Countess Markievicz** (1916) and **Winifred Carney** to establish a lineage of female resistance. The "Gibraltar Three" (Farrell, Dan McCann, Sean Savage) are frequently memorialized together to highlight the "shoot-to-kill" controversy.[8]
- **Kieran Nugent:** The first "blanket man" who refused to wear a prison uniform in 1976. Murals depicting Nugent often feature his iconic retort to prison guards: *"They'll have to nail it to my back."* This image of unbroken physical defiance is central to the "resistance" narrative of the H-Blocks.[8]
- **Jim Bryson and Paddy Mulvenna:** Specific to the Ballymurphy area, these volunteers were killed in 1973. Bryson is legendary in local lore for his escapes and close-quarters combat with the British Army. Murals in Ballymurphy dedicated to them serve a hyper-local function, asserting the area's reputation as a "no-go" zone for British forces during the height of the conflict.[8]

3. The Loyalist Citadel: Iconography of Defense in East Belfast

If the Republican narrative is one of *insurgency*, the Unionist/Loyalist narrative depicted in East Belfast (Lower Newtownards Road, Dee Street, Tamar Street) is one of *defense* and *maintenance*. The heroes here are not rebels against the state, but defenders of the state against internal treachery and external aggression.

3.1 The Founding Defenders: Heroes of the 1910s and 1920s

Loyalist murals draw a direct line of legitimacy from the formation of Northern Ireland to the modern paramilitary groups (UVF/UDA), arguing that the latter are merely the successors to the state's original defenders.

- **Colonel Fred Crawford (1861–1952):** A crucial figure for radical loyalism, Crawford organized the 1914 Larne Gun Running, smuggling 25,000 rifles from Germany for the UVF. Murals in East Belfast (Ballymacarrett Road) depict him overseeing the unloading of the *Clyde Valley*. He is a "radical" hero because he represents the willingness of Unionists to defy the British Parliament to maintain the Union—a "loyal rebel." He serves as a historical justification for loyalist paramilitaries acquiring arms: *it was right in 1914, so it is right today*.[11]
- **Sir Edward Carson (1854–1935):** The political architect of Unionism. His image is ubiquitous, often based on his statue at Stormont. He represents the law, the covenant, and the political legitimacy of the Northern Irish state. Murals often juxtapose him with modern gunmen to suggest that the UVF/UDA are the armed wing of Carson's political legacy.[14]
- **Sir James Craig (1871–1940):** The first Prime Minister of Northern Ireland. Murals depict him as the builder of the "Protestant Parliament for a Protestant People." He represents the consolidation of the state and the security apparatus.[12]
- **The 36th (Ulster) Division:** The soldiers who died at the Battle of the Somme (1916) are the most sacred figures in Unionist iconography. Murals on the Newtownards Road depicting soldiers going "over the top" are not just war memorials; they are political statements. They represent the "blood sacrifice" paid by Ulster for its place in the Union, a debt loyalists believe Britain has often betrayed.[16]
- **The B-Specials (1920–1970):** The Ulster Special Constabulary is memorialized in East Belfast murals as the original "anti-terrorist" force. Their disbandment in 1970 is portrayed in murals as the "Great Betrayal" by the British government, which necessitated the rise of the UDA and UVF to fill the security vacuum. Murals often feature the text *"Ulster's Past Defenders: B-Specials 1920–1970"* alongside modern paramilitaries.[17]

3.2 The Modern Defenders: Heroes of the 1970s and 1980s

As the state security forces became viewed as constrained by politics, loyalist murals began to celebrate the paramilitaries who "took the gloves off."

- **Billy Wright ("King Rat") (1960–1997):** Although associated with Mid-Ulster, Wright is a totemic figure in radical loyalist murals across Belfast. Murdered by the INLA inside the Maze Prison, he is depicted as a martyr who was "sold out" by the peace process. His image symbolizes uncompromising physical force against republicanism.[19]
- **Robert Dougan:** A leading member of the UDA South Belfast Brigade, killed by the PIRA in 1998 during the peace process negotiations. Murals in East Belfast commemorate him to highlight republican "duplicity" and the cost of the peace process to loyalists.[8]
- **Stevie "Top Gun" McKeag:**
  A UDA commander from the Shankill, celebrated in murals for his prolific "military" record (sectarian killings) in the early 1990s. He represents the "avenger" archetype—the loyalist who strikes back efficiently.
- **Francis Hughes (Complex Appropriation):** Interestingly, some loyalist murals reference republican figures like Francis Hughes (PIRA) not to honor them, but to demonize them as "sectarian killers," contrasting them with the "defensive" nature of loyalist heroes. For instance, murals may list victims of specific IRA units to counter the "freedom fighter" narrative.[8]
- **The East Belfast Brigade (UDA/UVF):** Unlike republican murals which often focus on individual charisma (Sands, Che Guevara), East Belfast murals frequently celebrate the *collective unit*—"G Company" or the "East Belfast Brigade." These murals feature anonymous, balaclava-clad men with automatic weapons, emphasizing the community's collective defense over individual celebrity.[16]

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4. The Intermediary: Linda Ervine and the Cultural Shift in East Belfast

While the murals demarcate the rigid boundaries of identity, a significant cultural shift is occurring within the citadel of East Belfast, led by Linda Ervine. Her work represents a disruption of the "two tribes" narrative, arguing for a shared cultural inheritance.

4.1 Background and Legitimacy

Linda Ervine's background provides her with a unique license to operate in loyalist East Belfast. She is not an outsider; she is the sister-in-law of the late **David Ervine**, the former leader of the Progressive Unionist Party (PUP) and a former UVF prisoner who was pivotal in delivering the loyalist ceasefire. Her husband, **Brian Ervine**, also led the PUP.[21] This lineage protects her from accusations of being a "republican stooge," allowing her to introduce the Irish language into spaces where it was previously viewed as an act of aggression.

4.2 The "Turas" Project: Reclaiming the Language

In 2011, Ervine established the **Turas** (Journey) project at the East Belfast Mission on the

Newtownards Road—a stronghold of unionism.

- **Mission:** The project aims to "connect people from Protestant communities to their own history with the Irish language".[21]
- **Scale:** Turas has grown to become one of the largest providers of Irish language classes in Belfast, with hundreds of weekly learners, the majority of whom are from Protestant/Unionist backgrounds.[23]
- **Institutional Expansion:** In 2021, Ervine was a key figure in the opening of **Naíscoil na Seolta**, the first Irish-medium pre-school in East Belfast. This marked a shift from adult curiosity to inter-generational transmission of the language within the unionist community.[24]

4.3 The "Unionist Concepts" for a Shared Island

Ervine's work offers a blueprint for how the Republic of Ireland might engage with Unionists—not by asking them to become "Irish" in a nationalist sense, but by validating their own distinct claim to the culture.

- **Protestant Preservation:** She lectures on the "Hidden History" of Protestants and the Irish language, pointing out that the Presbyterian Church required ministers to speak Irish in the 19th century and that the Gaelic League's first president, **Douglas Hyde**, was the son of a Church of Ireland rector.[21]
- **De-politicization:** Ervine argues that the Irish language belongs to everyone, challenging the Sinn Féin narrative that "every word of Irish spoken is a bullet in the freedom struggle." She urges the DUP and Orange Order to view the language not as a weapon, but as a shared heritage, citing the **Red Hand Commando's** motto *Lamh Dearg Abu* as evidence of Gaelic roots in loyalism.[21]
- **Recognition:** Her efforts were recognized when she became the first president of the East Belfast GAA in 2020 and received an MBE, further normalizing cross-community engagement.[21]

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5. The Economics of Reunification: US Funding and "Ireland's Future"

The campaign for a United Ireland has evolved from the clandestine fundraising of the Troubles to a highly professionalized, transparent political pressure campaign funded by the American diaspora.

5.1 From NORAID to Political Action

Historically, Irish-American funding was dominated by **NORAID** (Irish Northern Aid Committee), founded in 1969. While officially a relief organization for prisoners' families, it was widely accused by the US, British, and Irish governments of funding the PIRA's arms procurement. NORAID raised money through dinner dances and collections in bars in New York and Boston.[25]

5.2 Friends of Sinn Féin (FOSF)

Today, the primary vehicle for US funding is **Friends of Sinn Féin USA**.

- **Financials:** FOSF continues to be a fundraising juggernaut. In the 2022 period, it raised over **$1 million**. Recent FARA (Foreign Agents Registration Act) filings for 2024/2025 show continued high revenue streams. Notably, these funds **cannot** be used for electioneering in Ireland due to strict SIPO (Standards in Public Office) rules. Instead, the money is used to run the US operation, pay for Sinn Féin delegations to travel to the US, and fund advertising campaigns in US media (e.g., *The New York Times*, *Washington Post*) advocating for a border poll.[26]
- **Strategy:** The spending is strategic "soft power"—keeping Irish unity on the agenda in Washington and ensuring the US administration remains a guarantor of the Good Friday Agreement.

5.3 "Ireland's Future" and the AOH

A new entity, **Ireland's Future**, has emerged as a civic, non-party political group advocating for a unity referendum.

- **AOH Pivot:** The **Ancient Order of Hibernians (AOH)** in America has shifted its focus heavily toward supporting this constitutional conversation. In 2024/2025, the AOH's "Freedom for All Ireland" (FFAI) committee distributed grants totaling over **$150,000** to groups in Ireland, with "Ireland's Future" being a key recipient.[29]
- **Lobbying:** This funding supports conferences, research papers (on health, economy, etc. in a United Ireland), and lobbying efforts to pressure the British Secretary of State to call a border poll. High-profile US politicians like Congressman **Ritchie Torres** have aligned with this push, framing the British "Legacy Act" as a violation of victims' rights.[31]

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6. Sinn Féin and the 2024 Election: Analysis of a Stalled Momentum

Despite the "inevitability" narrative of a United Ireland, Sinn Féin suffered a significant strategic setback in the November 2024 Irish general election, failing to enter government.

6.1 The Results: High Votes, No Power

In the 2024 general election, Sinn Féin won **39 seats** (an increase of 2 from 2020) and **19.0%** of the first-preference vote. While they remain a major force, this was a catastrophic drop from polling highs of 30-35% seen in 2022/2023. They finished behind **Fianna Fáil (48 seats)** and effectively tied with **Fine Gael (38 seats)**.[32]

6.2 Why Did They Fail?

The failure to form a coalition or achieve a "Sinn Féin Taoiseach" was driven by three converging factors:

1. **The Immigration Wedge:** Sinn Féin's traditional working-class base rebelled against the party's progressive stance on immigration. As anti-immigrant sentiment rose in 2024, the party attempted to pivot but satisfied neither their progressive urban voters nor their nativist rural base. This vacuum allowed **Independents (who took 12.7% of the vote)** to surge, taking seats in Sinn Féin heartlands.[34]
2. **Transfer Toxicity:** Under Ireland's PR-STV system, being "transfer friendly" is vital. Fianna Fáil and Fine Gael voters transferred to each other in unprecedented numbers to keep Sinn Féin out. Sinn Féin candidates were often isolated in the final counts, unable to attract transfers from the center.[36]
3. **The Coalition of Stability:** Fianna Fáil and Fine Gael have effectively merged into a centrist bloc to exclude Sinn Féin. With 86 combined seats (just short of a majority of 88), they easily formed a government with Independents, rendering Sinn Féin irrelevant to the arithmetic of power.[37]

6.3 Party Members of Merit (The "Shadow" Cabinet)

The user requested an identification of merit-worthy members *outside* of the leadership triumvirate (McDonald, Doherty, Farrell). Sinn Féin possesses a deep bench of policy-heavyweights who often poll better than the party brand.

- **Eoin Ó Broin (Dublin Mid-West):** The party's Housing spokesperson. Ó Broin is widely regarded across the political spectrum as the party's "intellectual engine." He has authored authoritative books on housing policy (*Home*) and is credited with forcing the government to adopt housing as the number one political issue. His ability to debate complex policy detail makes him a critical asset, distinct from the populist rhetoric of others.[38]
- **David Cullinane (Waterford):** Health spokesperson. Cullinane is a vote-getting machine in Waterford, topping the poll with massive surpluses. He is viewed as an effective parliamentarian who has mastered the notoriously complex brief of the Health Service Executive (HSE). His style is forensic and detail-oriented.[38]
- **Louise O'Reilly (Dublin Fingal):** Spokesperson on Enterprise and Workers' Rights. A former SIPTU trade union official, she provides the party's vital link to the organized labour movement. She is a combative media performer and highly effective in committee hearings.[38]
- **Matt Carthy (Cavan-Monaghan):** Moved to the Justice portfolio in the 2025 reshuffle. A former MEP, Carthy represents the border-republican tradition. He is a strong orator and connects well with the party's rural base, which felt alienated in 2024.[41]
- **Rose Conway-Walsh (Mayo):** Spokesperson on Public Expenditure. She is a highly effective articulate voice for the "West of Ireland," focusing on regional inequality and infrastructure, crucial for the party's retention of rural seats.
- **Donnchadh Ó Laoghaire (Cork South-Central):** Moved to Foreign Affairs in 2025. A younger TD who holds his seat in the constituency of the Fianna Fáil leader Micheál Martin, demonstrating significant local popularity and political skill.[41]

7. The Crown and the Commonwealth: A Geopolitical Survey (2026)

A recurring argument in Unionist engagement (including by figures like Linda Ervine) is that a United Ireland could rejoin the Commonwealth to respect British identity. To assess this, one must understand the organization's current makeup.

7.1 Republics in the Commonwealth

As of February 2026, the Commonwealth of Nations is overwhelmingly a club of republics. Out of **56 member states**, **36 are republics**. These states recognize the King only as the symbolic "Head of the Commonwealth," not as their Head of State. This includes major powers like **India**, **South Africa**, **Pakistan**, and **Nigeria**.[42]

7.2 The Shrinking "Realms"

Only **15 states** (Commonwealth Realms) still recognize King Charles III as Head of State. This number is actively shrinking. **Barbados** became a republic in 2021. As of 2026, constitutional processes to transition to a republic are underway or proposed in **Jamaica**, **The Bahamas**, **Belize**, **Antigua and Barbuda**, and **Saint Vincent and the Grenadines**. It is projected that the number of realms will drop below 15 in the near future, normalizing the "Republic within the Commonwealth" model that a United Ireland might adopt.[45]

8. Conclusion

The path to constitutional change in Ireland is being paved not just by the "green dollar" of American fundraising or the electoral machinery of Sinn Féin, but by the slow, tectonic shifts in identity politics represented by Linda Ervine. While Sinn Féin struggles to convert its popularity into executive power in Dublin due to tactical missteps on immigration and transfers, the cultural barriers to unity in the North are being eroded by projects like Turas. The heroes of the past—from Crawford to Stagg—remain potent symbols, but the future of the island likely lies in the capacity of the Republic to construct a state that can accommodate the heirs of Carson as comfortably as the heirs of Tone, potentially within a Commonwealth framework that is itself rapidly de-colonizing.

Appendix A: Comparative Table of Radical Heroes

Tradition	1920s Hero	Significance	1970s/80s Equivalent	Significance	Mural Location
Republican	**Dan Breen**	Soloheadbeg Ambush; physical force	**Bobby Sands**	Hunger Strike; synthesis of soldier/politicia	Falls Road

		icon.		n.	
Republican	**Terence MacSwiney**	Hunger strike theorist; moral victory.	**Frank Stagg**	Repatriation struggle; British prison death.	West Belfast
Republican	**Tom Barry**	Flying Column tactician; guerrilla warfare.	**Mairéad Farrell**	Female volunteer; "active service" martyr.	International Wall
Loyalist	**Fred Crawford**	Larne Gun Runner; "Loyal Rebel."	**Billy Wright**	Paramilitary leader; defiance of peace process.	East Belfast
Loyalist	**36th Ulster Div.**	Blood sacrifice at Somme; debt owed by UK.	**B-Specials**	Disbanded defenders; betrayal by UK state.	Newtownards Rd
Loyalist	**Sir James Craig**	Architect of Northern state/security.	**Robert Dougan**	Victim of PIRA during peace talks.	Dee Street

Appendix B: Sinn Féin "Merit" List (Non-Leadership)

Name	Role (2025)	Key Strength
Eoin Ó Broin	Housing	Intellectual heavyweight; policy architect.
David Cullinane	Health	Poll-topper; master of complex HSE brief.
Louise O'Reilly	Enterprise	Trade Union link; strong media performer.
Matt Carthy	Justice	Rural connection; strong orator.
Rose Conway-Walsh	Public Expenditure	Voice for the West; regional inequality.

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